

RETAILSPHERE (PTY) LTD

BPA-001 — Stakeholder Interview Reference

Interview 1 — Sipho Dlamini

Full Name	Sipho Dlamini
Title	Head of Procurement
Domain	Procurement
Interview Date	17 April 2026
Interview Status	Complete
ADRs Triggered	ADR-001 (Master Product ID), ADR-003 (PDF Extraction)

1. Process Owner Profile

Sipho Dlamini is the Head of Procurement at RetailSphere. He manages the end-to-end procurement process across all 87 stores and the distribution centre, working with 340 active suppliers. He is a direct communicator who has been frustrated by the data limitations of the current SAP environment for several years. He walked into the interview with annotated SAP reports covered in red pen — evidence of the manual workarounds his team applies every month.

2. Key Business Processes

The procurement process at RetailSphere follows five stages:

- Stage 1 — Demand signal: Store POS flags low stock or planning team runs SAP replenishment report, triggering a Purchase Requisition (PR).
- Stage 2 — Purchase Order creation: Buyer selects supplier and raises PO. This decision is undocumented and lives in the buyer's head — no system support.
- Stage 3 — Supplier confirmation: Supplier confirms via email. Team manually updates SAP to mark PO as confirmed. High data quality risk if update is missed.
- Stage 4 — Goods Receipt: Warehouse team captures GRN in SAP against PO. Currently batch-captured at end of day — creating timestamp unreliability.
- Stage 5 — Invoice matching: Three-way match in SAP (PO + GRN + invoice). Exceptions managed in Excel by Johan's Finance team.
- Stage 6 — Payment: SAP payment run on 30, 60, or 90 day supplier terms depending on contract.

Key cross-domain dependency: GRN data quality is owned by Zanele Mokoena (Inventory Management) — not Sipho. The warehouse team that captures GRNs reports to Zanele, not Sipho. This means Sipho's procurement data quality depends on a team he does not manage.

3. Decisions Made — Daily, Weekly, Monthly

Daily

- Buyers review open POs and follow up on supplier confirmations.
- Manage exceptions queue — invoices that failed three-way match.
- Attend to urgent procurement issues flagged by store managers.

Weekly

- Procurement savings tracking — currently manual calculation.
- Supplier delivery performance review — currently unavailable in SAP.

Monthly

- Board reporting — procurement savings as percentage of total spend.
- Currently calculated manually by team over 3 days in Excel.
- Johan asks for this number every month-end. Sipho cannot produce it reliably without significant manual effort.

4. Questions Sipho Cannot Currently Answer

- Which suppliers are consistently late — and by how many days on average?
- Which suppliers have quality rejection rates above threshold?
- What is the price variance between contracted rates and what was actually paid?
- What are our Days Payable Outstanding by supplier?
- What is our procurement savings as a percentage of total spend — without 3 days of manual Excel work?

5. What Good Looks Like in 12 Months

Sipho's Monday morning dashboard — five metrics, no manual calculation:

- Supplier on-time delivery rate
- Invoice accuracy rate
- Price variance against contracted rates
- Days Payable Outstanding
- Procurement savings as % of total spend

Sipho's exact words:

"I want to wake up on Monday morning and see five numbers. That is what good looks like for me."

6. Data Sources and Quality Issues

Source Systems

- Primary: SAP ECC 6.0 — purchase orders, goods receipts, invoices, payments, supplier master data.

- Secondary: Supplier contracts — stored as PDF documents on a shared drive. Not in SAP.

Critical Data Quality Issues

Issue 1 — GRN Timestamps Unreliable

Goods arrive throughout the day. Warehouse team batch-captures GRNs at end of shift. SAP posting timestamp records 17h00 for goods that arrived at 09h00. On-time delivery calculation is impossible without reliable delivery timestamps.

Bronze layer workaround: Four timestamp columns per GRN record:

sap_posting_timestamp — when SAP recorded it

claimed_delivery_date — date on the delivery note

grn_capture_timestamp — when warehouse entered it

data_ingested_timestamp — when pipeline pulled it

Issue 2 — Supplier Contracts in PDF on Shared Drive

340 supplier contracts exist as unstructured PDF documents. Contracted rates, lead times, and payment terms are not in SAP. Price variance against contracted rates — one of Sipho's five required metrics — cannot be calculated without extracting structured data from these PDFs. ADR-003 raised.

Issue 3 — Invoice Exceptions Queue

847 invoices in exceptions queue. Some six months old. Managed in Excel by Johan's Finance creditors team. This is a process problem not a structural problem — the process can be improved. The platform makes the queue visible and measurable.

7. Architectural Implications

- Bronze layer: Four timestamp columns on every GRN record to separate event time from processing time.
- ADR-001: Master Product Identifier Strategy — SAP stock code must be resolved to POS code and Shopify SKU. Procurement domain is directly affected.
- ADR-003: Supplier Contract PDF Extraction — LLM-assisted hybrid approach recommended. pypdf extracts text. LLM structures the data. Human validation queue for low-confidence outputs.
- Architecture constraint confirmed: No new procurement software approved until data platform ROI is demonstrated. Platform must work with current broken process — not assume process is fixed first.
- Cross-domain dependency documented: GRN quality requires collaboration with Zanele Mokoena (Inventory domain). Fix requires cross-domain coordination.

8. Key Quote

"I have 340 active suppliers. I can tell you what I ordered and what I paid. I cannot tell you which suppliers are consistently late, which ones have quality rejection rates above threshold, or whether our payment terms are competitive versus what the market offers."

— Sipho Dlamini, Head of Procurement

— End of Interview Reference — Sipho Dlamini